



Applicant attraction to flexible work arrangements: Separating the influence of flextime and flexplace

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Flexible work arrangements (FWAs) are widely implemented for organizational purposes including recruitment. Theoretically, these arrangements alter temporal and physical boundaries around work. However, the time and place dimensions are frequently confounded in research, making the separate and joint effect of each on various outcomes unclear. To determine the relative importance of FWA dimensions as anticipated resources, this study experimentally manipulates discretion over when (flextime) and where (flexplace) one is expected to work on anticipated organizational support (AOS) and organization attraction. Prospective employees ($N = 130$) participated in a 3×3 within-subject experiment in which they rated nine hypothetical organizations that varied in flextime and flexplace. Results indicated main effects for both flextime and flexplace on both AOS and organization attraction with flextime having the stronger impact. Although the combination of a high level of both flextime and flexplace yielded the highest ratings of AOS and organization attraction, the interaction between flextime and flexplace was not statistically significant, suggesting flextime and flexplace have independent effects on recruitment outcomes. Relationships between flextime and flexplace and organizational attraction were slightly stronger for individuals who prefer to integrate their work and non-work roles. Managerial implications and directions for future research are discussed.

Practitioner points

- Potential applicants rate flextime without a required core time as significantly more supportive and attractive than flextime with core time.
- Potential applicants rate flextime with a required core time as significantly more supportive and attractive than no flextime.
- Potential applicants rate working from home 2 to 3 days a week as significantly more supportive and attractive than not being able to work from home at all.
- The supportiveness and attractiveness of flextime does not depend on the supportiveness or attractiveness of flexplace or vice versa.

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This article is based on Rebecca J. Thompson's master's thesis. We thank Drs. Winfred Arthur, Jr. and Murray Barrick for their feedback on an earlier draft of this paper. A previous version of this paper was presented at the 1st biannual Work Family Researchers Network, New York, NY, June, 2012.

Today, more organizations are recognizing that employees seek employment opportunities that offer resources to fulfil work and non-work role demands (Mantell, 2011; World at Work, 2009). One way organizations recognize employees' limited resources is to give employees more control over work boundaries by offering them flexible work arrangements (FWAs). These arrangements alter when and where work demands can be addressed, reducing work–non-work conflict (Hobfoll, 1989; Voyandoff, 2005). Offering FWAs signals employers' awareness and support of employees' multiple roles and demands (Grover & Crooker, 1995). Job seekers are likely to perceive FWAs as anticipated resources and take them into consideration during recruitment. As a result, FWAs can be used as a tool to meet organizational recruitment goals (Kossek & Friede, 2006).

Many forms of FWAs exist, such as telework, flextime schedules, compressed work weeks, and flexible shift work (Baltes, Briggs, Huff, Wright, & Neuman, 1999; Kossek, Hammer, Thompson, & Burke, 2014). Multiple studies have shown that FWAs are associated with a number of positive outcomes for current employees (Baltes *et al.*, 1999; Gajendran & Harrison, 2007; Kossek & Michel, 2011), as well as prospective employees (Casper & Buffardi, 2004). Theoretically, FWAs offer employees some degree of control over the temporal and/or physical boundaries around which they work (Voyandoff, 2005). Thus, FWAs vary on two independent but related dimensions: *Discretion over work time* and *discretion over work place* (Allen, Johnson, Kiburz, & Shockley, 2013; Butler, Grzywacz, Ettner, & Liu, 2009). If it is possible for employees to work 'anywhere', it is also likely that they can work 'anytime'. Thus, organizations that offer discretion over where work is conducted also tend to offer discretion over when work is conducted (World at Work, 2011), but not always.

Flexible work arrangement researchers do not always differentiate between the multiple dimensions of discretion that are inherent within specific policies. This raises doubts about the scientific evidence supporting the individual policies, as it is impossible to know the relative desirability and influence of each dimension of discretion when they are studied together. As a result, practice is not informed by good science. By systematically varying multiple levels of each FWA dimension, we reveal the effect of FWA dimensions as anticipated resources to recruitment outcomes. New insights are also gained about the relative importance of temporal versus physical work boundaries, providing valuable information for the design and marketing of FWAs.

We conducted a within-subject full-factorial vignette experiment, following many of the best practices recommended by Aguinis and Bradley (2014). We systematically vary the two focal independent variables flextime and flexplace to be one of the three levels. By having each participant rate each vignette, we can estimate the effect of two practical increases in discretion over when and where work is conducted. We test the increases from no discretion to some discretion and from some discretion to unlimited discretion. This design permits an examination of three levels of each FWA dimension relative to the others, as well as all corresponding combinations of flextime and flexplace.

Our study contributes to the research literature by addressing a number of limitations previously documented. Specifically, two recent reviews (Allen & Shockley, 2009; Casper, Eby, Bordeaux, Lockwood, & Lambert, 2007) identified only one study of work schedules using an experimental design. As a result, the large majority of conclusions made about FWAs are based on correlational data that assume linear relationships. This is problematic because compared to other research designs, experiments have the highest level of internal validity and permit causal inferences. Researchers have noted that

examining different levels of flexibility is critical to pinpointing the degree of flexibility that offers positive outcomes (Christensen & Staines, 1990), calling for 'a more nuanced approach to how we assess FWA' (Allen & Shockley, 2009, p. 279) to determine the relative importance of the various levels of FWA dimensions.

Flexible work arrangements

Flexible work arrangements are 'a mutually beneficial arrangement between employees and employers in which both parties agree on when, where and how the employee will work to meet the firm's needs' (Kossek *et al.*, 2014, p. 2). Although there are variations of the traditional workday, we use the 8 am–5 pm Monday through Friday work week as a comparison. Two of the most widely implemented and therefore studied FWAs in the United States and Europe are flextime and flexplace (Matos & Galinsky, 2012; Shockley & Allen, 2007; Stavrou, 2005). In fact, the number of wage and salaried employees given a flextime option has increased dramatically in recent years (Galinsky, Bond, Sakai, Kim, & Giuntoli, 2008; Matos & Galinsky, 2012). As Galinsky *et al.* note, flexibility is no longer just a perk to be offered but a competitive tool that organizations can use to meet their strategic recruitment objectives. Organizations seeking to maximize talent attraction and retention frequently utilize FWAs to gain a competitive edge (Barney, 1991; Kossek *et al.*, 2014; SHRM, 2013; World at Work, 2011).

Theoretical foundations

Theoretically, the reason why prospective employees are likely to find FWAs attractive is because they signal to applicants that the organization cares about employees (Grover & Crooker, 1995; Spence, 1973), and such arrangements extend more control to employees facilitating their ability to meet work and non-work demands. According to signalling theory, prospective applicants interpret observable information conveyed by an organization as signs or signals of less observable characteristics (Spence, 1973). In the context of recruitment, applicants infer the extent to which an organization is 'family-friendly' based on the types of policies offered (Casper & Harris, 2008; Grover & Crooker, 1995).

The appeal or attractiveness of FWAs is often explained by Hobfoll's (1989, 2001) conservation of resources theory and Voyandoff's (2005) resources and demands model. According to these theories, people are motivated to conserve resources (Hobfoll, 1989, 2001) because they rely on them to meet environmental demands (Voyandoff, 2005). Resources have been defined as 'anything perceived by the individual to help attain his or her goals', and discretion is one of the ways that resources have been operationalized in the research literature (Halbesleben, Neveu, Paustian-Underdahl, & Westman, 2014, p. 1338). Likewise, FWAs have been described as 'boundary-spanning resources' (Voyandoff, 2005) as they facilitate the ability to perform the work role in the non-work domain and quickly transition between roles.

In a recruitment context, applicants rather than employees evaluate FWAs and contemplate what it will be like to work for that organization. We propose that FWAs can be conceptualized as *anticipated* resources and that consistent with resource and demand theories, they will be motivated to conserve and retain such resources to reduce strain resulting from multiple role demands. When evaluating a given organization, applicants will consider their current resources as well as anticipated resources offered by the organization. Based on resource theories, applicants will be more attracted to

organizations they can anticipate more resources from rather than less. Further, FWAs may signal to potential applicants that if they were to work for this company, they can anticipate being able to meet both work and non-work demands with some ease and therefore experience less work–non-work conflict, because they will have flexible work boundaries.

While it is generally accepted that FWAs are desirable (Cook, 2009), the value of these resources is determined by the individual as well as his or her personal context (Halbesleben *et al.*, 2014). In other words, resources are not organized hierarchically in terms of importance; rather, their attractiveness is relative to the individual and his or her unique demands. Some researchers have begun to speculate that in addition to the resources themselves, various aspects or dimensions of the resources also matter. For example, Payne, Cook, and Diaz (2012) recently demonstrated that the convenience of the childcare resource was related to time-based family interference with work, absenteeism, and turnover intentions. Correspondingly, in this study, we differentiate FWAs that permit discretion over when work is conducted from those that permit discretion over where work is conducted. It is unclear whether potential applicants find the option to alter temporal boundaries more or less desirable than the option to alter physical boundaries. Further, it has not been empirically tested whether it is more desirable to have discretion over both time and place and, if so, how much of each type of discretion is preferred. From a practical perspective, it is important to determine the relative effectiveness of each FWA dimension offered to identify their unique contributions. Next, we describe the nature of each dimension individually and together.

Flextime

Discretion over when employees work, the days and the hours, is a core dimension on which FWAs can vary. Operationally, a *flextime schedule* includes ‘core time’ in which employees are required to work (e.g., 9 am–3 pm, Monday–Friday) and ‘flexible time’, corresponding to the hours employees can choose to conduct work (e.g., 6 am–9 am, 3 pm–6 pm, Monday–Friday; Baltes *et al.*, 1999; Kossek *et al.*, 2014). Thus, flextime increases the time periods employees are available for non-work demands by giving employees some discretion over their start and stop work times each day. Research suggests that work and non-work demands have increased, competing for the finite resource of time (Jacobs & Gerson, 1998) making the ability to control when one works all the more valuable.

Consistent with Shockley and Allen (2007), we use the term *flextime* to refer to the extent to which employees can alter temporal boundaries around work. The underlying construct is discretion or freedom to make changes to work time which is conceptually continuous, ranging from no discretion (i.e., set hours on set days) to unlimited discretion (no set hours/days).

Flexplace

Discretion over where employees conduct work is another core dimension on which FWAs can vary. Traditionally, employees ‘go to’ work, such that they leave home to conduct their work at an alternative physical location (e.g., office building). Here, employees can access information they need to do their work and communicate with important constituents (supervisors, coworkers, clients, etc.). When organizations permit

employees to work from alternative locations, they give employees more options as to where they can conduct their work.¹ We use the term *flexplace* to refer to the extent to which employees can alter physical boundaries around work. Like flextime, flexplace is a continuous construct ranging from no discretion to unlimited discretion over working away from the main worksite (cf. Bailey & Kurland, 2002). Operationally, this might be conveyed as how frequently (number of days a week/month) employees are permitted to work in an alternative location.

Flexplace is frequently studied and implemented in practice as telework or telecommuting (Shockley & Allen, 2007) whereby ‘employees perform tasks elsewhere that are normally done in a primary or central workplace, for at least some portion of their work schedule, using electronic media to interact with others inside and outside the organization’ (Gajendran & Harrison, 2007, p. 1525; see also the definition of telework in the US Telework Enhancement Act of 2010; US Congress, 2010; section 6501). According to these definitions, telework alters *where* work is conducted. Note that the definition does not involve altering *when* work is conducted.

The confounding of flextime with flexplace

Theoretically, discretion over time is independent of discretion over place (Allen *et al.*, 2013; Shockley & Allen, 2007). Correspondingly, FWA policies can take a variety of forms, with organizations extending flextime without extending flexplace and vice versa. However, in practice and in research, flextime and flexplace are sometimes extended together or combined into one policy. For example, telework policies that permit employees to work at an alternative location on non-traditional days/times extend discretion over both temporal and physical work boundaries (Standen, Daniels, & Lamond, 1999). The organizations that tend to offer flexplace policies (i.e., telework) also tend to offer flextime policies (World at Work, 2011). Sixty-nine of *Fortune Magazine’s* 100 Best Companies to Work For in 2014 offered both flexible scheduling and telecommuting (T. Russell, personal communication, 2014). It is not clear, however, whether employees are permitted to utilize both policies at the same time. This study tests the extent to which having discretion over both time and place is attractive.

Perhaps because flextime and flexplace are frequently extended together, research on FWAs has become a bit muddled. Some researchers conceptualize telework within a given study as discretion over *both* place and time (e.g., Major, Verive, & Joice, 2008; Pearlson & Saunders, 2001; Stavrou & Kilaniotis, 2010). For example, teleworkers have sometimes been referred to as ‘anytime, anywhere workers’ (e.g., Lister & Harnish, 2011). Also, authors (e.g., Overmyer, 2011) tout ‘flexibility in scheduling work’ (p. 10) as a recognized employee benefit of telework without explicitly acknowledging that such a benefit would require flextime as well. Similarly, research studies indicate that teleworkers report that telework ‘provides flexibility in your daily schedule’ as a way that teleworking assists with dependent care situations (Major *et al.*, 2008, p. 75). These findings imply that teleworkers have discretion over time, but this is not

¹ It is important to distinguish between policies that extend discretion to employees giving them flexibility over where they work from those that require employees to work off-site or travel to meet client/organizational needs. Whereas FWAs can be used to meet employee, client, and/or organizational needs, they are, by definition, flexible such that they give the employee discretion over where work is conducted. Flexplace should also be distinguished from remote work in which employees do not have dedicated space at a traditional worksite.

consistent with the original definition of telework or how it is always implemented (Rau & Hyland, 2002).

Similarly, several studies examining the relationship of 'workplace flexibility' or 'family-friendly policies' with various outcomes lump several or sometimes all categories of FWAs together, rather than examining them individually (e.g., Butler *et al.*, 2009; Butts, Casper, & Yang, 2013; Uggerslev, Fassina, & Kraichy, 2012). In fact, despite making the claim that it is important to distinguish between flextime and flexplace, in a recent meta-analysis, all telework studies were coded as flexplace, ignoring the possibility that employees may have also been permitted to alter *when* work was conducted (Allen *et al.*, 2013). As a result, the independent effects of flexplace remain ambiguous.

We argue that it is phenomenologically different to have the option to alter time and not place, or place and not time, as well as the option to alter both. In the next section, we elaborate on the various combinations of flextime and flexplace and how each arrangement differs.

Flextime without flexplace: A flextime without flexplace arrangement permits employees to alter temporal but not physical boundaries around work. In this arrangement, employees can come to the worksite earlier or later than a traditional start time, allowing them to tend to non-work demands during traditional work hours. For example, an employee might take a pet to the veterinarian's office for an 8-am appointment, take the pet home, and begin his/her workday at the main worksite at 10 am, working later in the day to fulfil an 8-hr workday. Many non-work demands can only be attended to during traditional work hours (e.g., child's doctor's appointment at 2 pm on Tuesday). Compared to a traditional work schedule, employees with traditional flextime schedules have wider ranges of time to devote to non-work demands. Based on resource theories, we predict that higher levels of flextime will be rated as significantly more supportive and attractive than lower levels of flextime.

Hypothesis 1: There is a significant main effect for flextime on (a) AOS and (b) organization attraction.

Flexplace without flextime: When employees have discretion over *where* they work but not *when* they work, they have the option to alter their physical but not their temporal boundaries. Employees are expected to be working and available via various forms of communication technology during the organization's mandated working hours. This arrangement allows employees to conduct their work in more convenient and comfortable locations. Not having to report to a central work location can result in both fiscal and temporal benefits such as eliminating commute time and decreasing the amount of money spent on transportation and work clothes. By altering the physical boundary surrounding where work is conducted, employees can more quickly transition from their work role to a non-work role.

Flexplace without flextime means employees do not have the ability to attend to non-work demands that arise *during* the organization's mandated work hours. For example, employees cannot supervise children/elders or take care of home chores while also conducting work tasks. Some researchers contend that employees with discretion over *where* they work without discretion over *when* they work have little more control than

employees working at the main work site (Shockley & Allen, 2007). Like flextime, we anticipated that higher levels of flexplace will be associated with significantly higher ratings of support and attraction.

Hypothesis 2: There is a significant main effect for flexplace on (a) AOS and (b) organization attraction.

Flexplace with flextime: Flexplace *with* flextime means employees have discretion over both temporal and physical work boundaries. This combination extends the range of time in which work can be conducted in virtually any location. Thus, flextime augments the benefits of flexplace by allowing for more fluid transitions between roles that accommodate the employer as well as the employee. For instance, an employee may quickly transition from the role of an employee working on a report to homeowner monitoring home repair in a matter of seconds, increasing the amount of time s/he is available for both roles by avoiding costly transitions between roles (e.g., driving home from the main worksite; Ashforth, Kreiner, & Fugate, 2000).

Conservation of resource theorists speculate that some resources typically occur together which Hobfoll (1988) refers to as 'resource caravans'. A combination of a high level of flextime and a high level of flexplace results in an arrangement with the most discretion over temporal and physical boundaries, but we propose that the combination is synergistic, not just additive. Human resource researchers have speculated that policies that are 'properly configured' result in better outcomes, because bundles of practices 'simultaneously exploit the potential for complementarities or synergies among such practices' (Huselid, 1995, p. 636). Like other researchers (cf. Shockley & Allen, 2010), we conceptualize flextime as an enhancing moderator of the flexplace–outcome relationships. In other words, flextime augments the value of flexplace.

Hypothesis 3: There will be a significant interaction between flextime and flexplace on (a) AOS and (b) organization attraction such that the relationship between flexplace and these outcomes will be stronger for higher levels of flextime.

FWA, anticipated organizational support, and organization attraction

Based on signalling theory (Spence, 1973), Grover and Crooker (1995) proposed that offering FWAs conveys organizational concern and support (Meyer, 1979). Applicants can become aware of and form opinions about an organization's culture based on information gathered through the recruitment process and therefore develop expectations about the organization as a result (Casper & Buffardi, 2004). In a study examining potential applicants' intentions to pursue jobs with specific characteristics, Casper and Buffardi (2004) found that anticipated organizational support (AOS) mediated the relationship between schedule flexibility and job pursuit intentions. Thus, research supports that potential applicants infer organizational support from policies offered which can impact job-related decisions. Therefore, it is likely that individuals will rate organizations offering more flextime as significantly more attractive, in part because of inferences made about organizational support.

Hypothesis 4: AOS will partially mediate the relationship between flextime and organization attraction.

Hypothesis 5: AOS will partially mediate the relationship between flexplace and organization attraction.

Does the attractiveness of FWAs depend on individual differences?

Theoretically, FWAs are most desirable to those who anticipate a need or preference for using these policies. Correspondingly, the relationship between discretion over when and where one works and recruitment outcomes may depend on some demographic and individual differences. An examination of moderators of these relationships reveals important conditions to be considered when implementing such policies.

Sex

Although both men and women are interested in flexible workplace policies (Linkow, Civian, & Lingle, 2011), the likelihood of using a policy and the nature of the policy used differ between men and women (Bond, Galinsky, Kim, & Brownfield, 2005; Hill, Martinson, Hawkins, & Ferris, 2003; Hill *et al.*, 2008). Researchers examining differences in sandwiched generation couples propose that wives may select jobs that offer more flexibility than their husbands (Hammer & Neal, 2008); perhaps, because women tend to anticipate more work–family conflict than men (Burley, 1994; Cinamon, 2006). Therefore, it seems likely that men and women may be differentially attracted to organizations that offer FWAs. We hypothesize that sex will moderate the relationships between flextime/flexplace and organization attraction.

Hypothesis 6: Sex moderates the flextime–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for women than men.

Hypothesis 7: Sex moderates the flexplace–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for women than men.

Preference for integration

Preference for integration describes the extent to which individuals maintain boundaries between their various work and non-work roles (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Kossek, Lautsch, & Eaton, 2006; Kreiner, 2006). Some individuals prefer to separate their work and non-work roles, whereas others prefer to integrate or blur the boundaries between work and non-work, allowing for more overlap of roles and tasks. Shockley and Allen (2010) found that individuals with a higher level of a ‘need for segmentation’ (the opposite of preference for integration) used FWAs less frequently than those with less of a need for segmentation. These results suggest that people who prefer to integrate their work and non-work roles will be more attracted to organizations offering FWAs than individuals who prefer to segment their roles.

Hypothesis 8: Preference for integration moderates the flextime–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for people who prefer to integrate rather than segment.

Hypothesis 9: Preference for integration moderates the flexplace–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for people who prefer to integrate rather than segment.

Anticipated caregiving demands

A third individual difference that may alter the attractiveness of FWAs is caregiving demands. Individuals caring for dependent children and/or elders are likely to seek work arrangements that give them discretion over temporal and physical work boundaries to better manage these demands. Indeed, researchers have indicated that to attract and retain employees with multiple dependent care responsibilities, employers should find ways to implement and maximize flexibility (Hammer & Neal, 2008). Compared to applicants who do not anticipate having caregiving demands, we hypothesize that individuals who do anticipate having caregiving demands will have a stronger preference for organizations that offer FWAs.

Hypothesis 10: Anticipated caregiving demands moderate the flextime–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for people who anticipate having such demands compared to those who do not.

Hypothesis 11: Anticipated caregiving demands moderate the flexplace–organization attraction relationship such that the relationship is stronger for people who anticipate having such demands compared to those who do not.

Method

Participants

Study participants consisted of primarily upper-level undergraduate students from a large university in the south-west United States. Instructors of junior- and senior-level classes from multiple departments were contacted and asked to offer their students the opportunity to participate in this study, with the option of awarding extra credit as determined by the instructors. One hundred and ninety students responded. The final sample was limited to the 130 respondents who correctly answered all eight manipulation check items. The sample was largely White (75%) women (63%) and on average 21.13 ($SD = 1.14$) years of age. The majority of the participants were juniors or seniors (77%)² and therefore likely to be looking for jobs in the near future.

Study design and procedure

A 3 (flexplace: (1) not permitted to work from home, (2) permitted to work from home up to 2 days a week, and (3) permitted to work from home) $\times$ 3 (flextime: (1)

² Analyses were also conducted with a subsample of 99 juniors and seniors, and statistical significance of the results did not differ.

traditional work schedule, (2) core hours 10 am–3 pm, and (3) free to work at any time they want) within-subject experiment was conducted. Similar to other policy-capturing experiments (e.g., Harold & Ployhart, 2008; Thompson & Aspinwall, 2009), each participant read short descriptions of nine hypothetical organizations offering the same level of salary and benefits but varying levels of flexplace and flextime (see Appendix for sample organizational descriptions). The organizational descriptions were presented to participants in a random order to minimize order and sequence effects.

Measures

Table 1 shows descriptive statistics, zero-order correlations, and coefficient alphas for Level 1 and Level 2 variables. Participants rated AOS and organization attraction on a 5-point scale (1 = not at all, 5 = extremely) for each organization description; thus, these variables were assessed nine times by each respondent. They also completed demographic questions at the end of the survey.

Manipulation check items

After participants rated all nine hypothetical organizations, they were presented with eight manipulation check items. The items were designed to determine whether participants differentiated between the characteristics of the organizations that were manipulated versus the ones that were not. They also served as a quality check for non-serious responding. An example item read 'Did the organizations differ on whether or not they offered Flextime?' An additional item read 'Did the organizations differ on whether or not they offered a competitive salary?' Participants responded 'yes' or 'no'.

Table 1. Descriptive statistics and zero-order correlations for study variables

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	Level 1			
			1	2	3	
1. Sex	1.67	0.47	—			
2. Preference for integration	2.89	0.66	−.08**	(.75)		
3. Anticipated caregiving responsibilities	3.54	0.66	.13**	−.04	(.89)	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	Level 2			
			1	2	3	4
1. Flextime	—	—	—			
2. Flexplace	—	—	—	—		
3. AOS	3.67	0.80	.13**	.09**	(.90)	
4. Organization attraction	3.83	0.84	.22**	.16**	.39**	(.93)

Note. AOS, anticipated organizational support.

Level 1: *N* = 1,160. Level 2: *N* = 130. Where applicable, reliabilities (coefficient alphas) appear in italics on the diagonal. Sex: Male = 1 and female = 2.

p* ≤ .05; *p* ≤ .01 (two-tailed).

Anticipated organizational support

Modelled after Casper and Buffardi's (2004) adaptation of Eisenberger, Cummings, Armeli, and Lynch's (1997) Perceived Organizational Support Scale, AOS was measured with the following three items: 'This organization would really care about my well-being', 'This organization would be willing to help me if I need a special favor', and 'This organization would show concern for me'.

Organization attraction

Organization attraction was measured using three items used in other recruitment studies (Aiman-Smith, Bauer, & Cable, 2001; Harold & Ployhart, 2008). An example item read 'How attracted are you to this organization?'

Preference for integration

Five questions were adapted from Kreiner's (2006) preference for segmentation scale which assesses the degree to which individuals prefer to separate their home and work lives. An example item read 'I don't like to have to think about work when I'm at home'. Respondents indicated the extent to which they agreed with each statement on a 5-point scale, and items were scored such that higher scores represent a stronger preference to integrate rather than separate roles.

Anticipated caregiving demands

Participants' anticipated caregiving demands were assessed via three items, asking about expectations for providing eldercare and childcare. Participants were asked one item about whether they planned to have/adopt children in the future. They were asked the following two questions about expected eldercare demands: 'Do you anticipate playing a role in taking care of your parents in the future?' and 'To what extent do you feel there is a cultural or family expectation that your parents will live with you someday?' (1 = not at all, 3 = somewhat likely, 5 = very likely).

Results

To confirm that the dependent variables, AOS and organization attraction, were distinct, we conducted a series of confirmatory factor analyses with Mplus 6.0 (Muthén & Muthén, 1998–2010). The results indicated that the scale items loaded onto their respective constructs (i.e., a two-factor model) with good model fit (comparative fit index = .99; root mean square error of approximation = .04; standardized root mean square residual = .02). These results suggest that common method bias is not a problem and that AOS and organization attraction are distinct constructs.

Multilevel models (Table 1) were used to assess the influence of flextime and flexplace on AOS and organization attraction. All models were estimated as random intercept models. The multilevel structure was used to take into account the clustering of repeated measures within individuals. For hierarchical random effects models, explained variance is calculated as the proportion reduction in variance (*prv*; Bryk & Raudenbush, 1992; Prosser, Rasbash, & Goldstein, 1991).

Hypotheses 1 predicted that flextime would significantly impact (1) organizational support and (2) organization attraction. Flextime had a significant main effect on AOS, $F(1, 1029.59) = 44.59$, $p < .05$; $prv = .04$, and organization attraction, $F(1, 1030.11) = 92.66$, $p < .05$; $prv = .08$, supporting Hypotheses 1a and 1b. Pairwise mean comparisons for the different levels of flextime were performed by re-estimating the multilevel model repeatedly, with only two levels of the flextime factor included each time. As depicted in Table 2, significant differences emerged between all three levels of flextime (high, moderate, and none) for both AOS and organization attraction. Consistent with H1a and H1b, participants rated organizations that offered more flextime as incrementally more supportive and attractive than organizations that offered less or no flextime.

Hypothesis 2 examined the same outcomes with flexplace. Flexplace also had a significant main effect on AOS, $F(1, 1029.67) = 21.47$, $p < .05$; $prv = .02$, and organization attraction, $F(1, 1030.25) = 48.43$, $p < .05$; $prv = .04$, supporting Hypotheses 2a and 2b. Pairwise mean comparisons for the different levels of flexplace revealed significant differences in AOS and organization attraction between all the levels of flexplace with two exceptions (see Table 2). In all cases, higher levels of flexibility resulted in higher ratings of support and attraction. However, a high level of flexplace ($M = 3.76$, $SD = 0.84$) was not rated as significantly more supportive than a moderate level of flexplace, $M = 3.75$, $SD = 0.78$, $t(642.32) = 0.85$, $p > .05$. Similarly, a high level of flexplace ($M = 4.00$, $SD = 0.83$) was not significantly more attractive than a moderate level of flexplace, $M = 3.96$, $SD = 0.78$, $t(642.80) = 0.30$, $p > .05$. Thus, respondents did not meaningfully distinguish in their ratings between a moderate and a high level of flexplace as operationalized in this study. In summary, consistent with H2a and 2b, organizations that offer some discretion over where work is conducted were rated as significantly more supportive and attractive than organizations that do not offer such discretion.

Hypothesis 3 proposed that there would be an interaction between flextime and flexplace on AOS and organization attraction. Contrary to the prediction, the interaction

Table 2. Means of anticipated organizational support (AOS) and organization attraction by experimental condition

	No flextime <i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)	Moderate flextime <i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)	High flextime <i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)	Flexplace collapsing flextime <i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)
High flexplace	3.63 (0.78)	3.75 (0.80)	3.88 (0.91)	3.76 ^a (0.84)
	3.77 (0.80)	4.05 (0.79)	4.19 (0.86)	4.00 ^b (0.83)
Moderate flexplace	3.60 (0.74)	3.75 (0.72)	3.87 (0.74)	3.75 ^a (0.74)
	3.67 (0.80)	4.08 (0.72)	4.14 (0.75)	3.96 ^b (0.78)
No flexplace	3.47 (0.80)	3.62 (0.73)	3.67 (0.74)	3.58 (0.76)
	3.44 (0.83)	3.74 (0.76)	3.86 (0.74)	3.68 (0.80)
Flextime collapsing flexplace	3.56 (0.82)	3.71 (0.75)	3.81 (0.81)	
	3.57 (0.78)	3.95 (0.77)	4.07 (0.80)	

Note. $N = 130$.

^aConditions of flexplace that were not significantly different from one another on AOS, $t(642.38) = 0.09$, $p > .05$.

^bConditions of flexplace that were not significantly different from one another on organization attraction, $t(642.80) = 0.72$, $p > .05$. All marginal means for flextime were significantly different from one another.

between flextime and flexplace was not statistically significant for AOS, $F(1, 1027.29) = 0.26$, $p > .05$, nor organization attraction, $F(1, 1027.72) = 0.02$, $p > .05$. Thus, the influence of flexplace on organizational support and organization attraction does not *depend on* nor is it enhanced or diminished by flextime. Therefore, Hypotheses 3a and 3b were not supported.

Hypotheses 4 and 5 proposed AOS as a partial mediator of the flextime/flexplace–organization attraction relationships. Consistent with H4, when flextime was controlled for, the relationship between AOS and organization attraction remained significant, $F(1, 983.37) = 520.04$, $p < .05$. As stated above, flextime was a positive predictor of AOS (typically labelled the ‘a’ path in mediation analysis), which positively predicted organization attraction (the ‘c’ path). Thus, there was evidence that AOS partially mediated the relationship between flextime and organization attraction, supporting Hypothesis 4.

As noted in the analyses for Hypothesis 2a and 2b, flexplace predicted both AOS (the ‘a’ path) and organization attraction (the ‘c’ path). Consistent with H5, when flexplace was controlled for, the relationship between AOS and organization attraction remained significant, $F(1, 986.38) = 546.96$, $p < .05$. This provides evidence that AOS partially mediated the relationship between flexplace and organization attraction; therefore, Hypothesis 5 was also supported.

Moderators

In support of H6 and H7, there was a significant interaction between sex and flextime on organization attraction, $F(1, 1011.94) = 7.49$, $p < .05$, as well as between sex and flexplace on organization attraction, $F(1, 1012.12) = 5.72$, $p < .05$. Incremental increases in both flextime and flexplace were perceived as more attractive to both groups, but post hoc analyses revealed no significant differences between men and women at each level of flextime/flexplace.³ The omnibus test appeared to reflect that women tended to report higher means for no and some flextime compared to men. Data were less interpretable for flexplace, but we hesitate to interpret these given the way that high flexplace was operationalized. Therefore, H6 and H7 were not supported.

Consistent with H8 and H9, there were significant interactions between preference for integration and flextime, $F(1, 998.16) = 18.03$, $p < .05$, as well as flexplace on organization attraction, $F(1, 998.18) = 30.53$, $p < .05$, such that these relationships were stronger for those who prefer to integrate than those who prefer to segment (see Figures 1 and 2). Finally, there was not a significant interaction between anticipated caregiving demands and *flextime* on organization attraction, $F(1, 1020.03) = 0.00$, $p > .05$, nor between anticipated caregiving demands and *flexplace* on organization attraction, $F(1, 1020.10) = 0.05$, $p > .05$. These results fail to support H10 and H11.

Discussion

The current study extends previous research by measuring the relative attractiveness of experimentally manipulated levels of anticipated organizational resources. Researchers

³ For men, means and standard deviations were 3.47 (0.82), 3.91 (0.78), and 4.09 (0.76) for none, some, and unlimited flextime, respectively. Corresponding descriptive statistics for women were 3.67 (0.80), 3.96 (0.77), and 4.03 (0.82). For flexplace, men were 3.71 (0.83), 3.90 (0.74), and 3.87 (0.89), and women were 3.64 (0.78), 3.97 (0.80), and 4.05 (0.79).

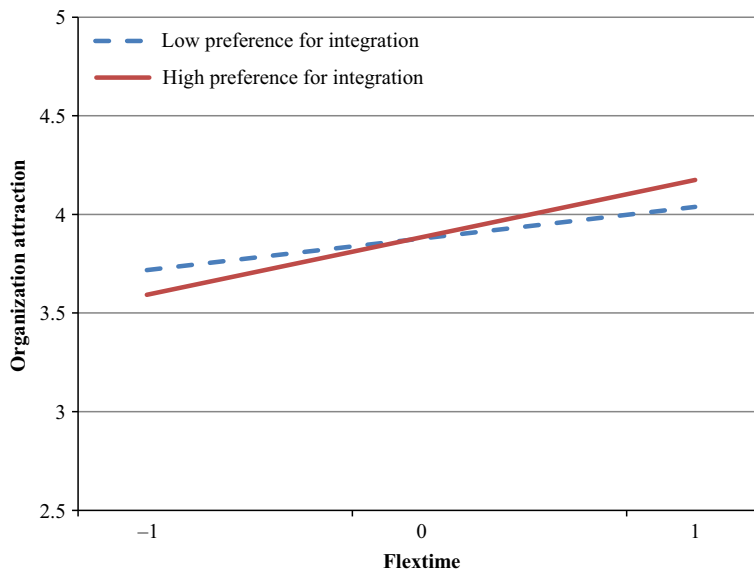


Figure 1. Interaction of flextime and preference for integration on organization attraction.

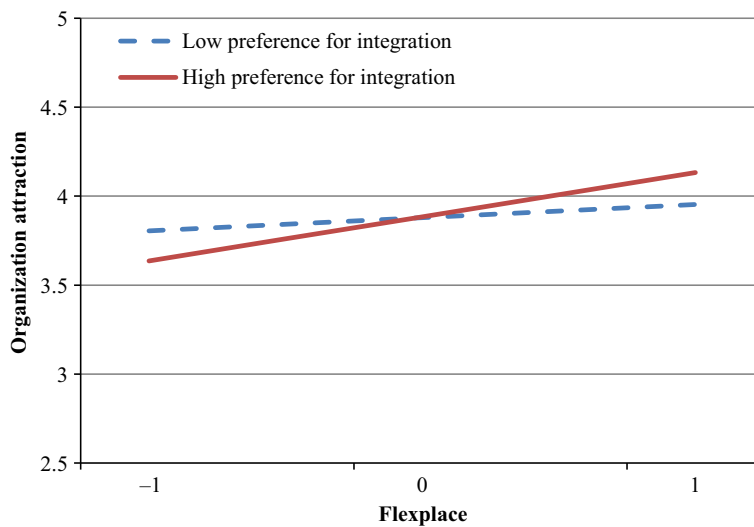


Figure 2. Interaction between flexplace and preference for integration on organization attraction.

have found that organizations offering FWAs are more attractive to applicants than those that do not (Casper & Buffardi, 2004; Rau & Hyland, 2002; Thompson & Aspinwall, 2009), potentially signalling the organization's underlying values and concerns for employees (Grover & Crooker, 1995; Spence, 1973). However, due to the confounding of FWAs dimensions in research and practice, the extent to which flextime and flexplace independently and/or jointly contribute to organization attraction was unclear, leaving the value of FWA dimensions to recruitment outcomes unknown (Dineen & Soltis, 2011; Rynes & Cable, 2003). Using a within-subject full-factorial vignette experiment, the

current study demonstrated that practical increases in discretion over *when* and *where* can one work result in meaningfully higher ratings of AOS and attraction.

Flextime versus flexplace

Based on the premise that FWAs signal organizational support to future employees (cf. Greenberg, 1990; Grover & Crooker, 1995; Meyer, 1979) and previous research has shown that flexible benefits are perceived as supportive (Casper & Buffardi, 2004; Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002), we posited and found that applicants rate organizations that offer more discretion over when work is conducted as significantly more attractive than organizations that offer less or no discretion over work time, because these organizations are perceived as significantly more supportive.

Likewise, participants also rated organizations offering more discretion over *where* work is conducted as significantly more supportive and attractive. Interestingly, organizations offering the most discretion over where work is conducted were rated as supportive and attractive as the organizations offering a moderate amount of discretion over work place. Thus, participants in this study did not perceive an appreciable difference between a moderate and high amount of flexplace. There are two possible explanations for this. First, despite how we intended to operationalize a high level of flexplace, we realized after the study that the high flexplace condition did not explicitly indicate that individuals could work away from the main worksite as many days as desired. Instead, the description simply read 'work from home via technology such as a computer'. In contrast, the moderate level of flexplace read 'work from home via technology such as a computer up to 2 days a week'. The potential ambiguity over how frequently one could work from home in the high condition may have contributed to the lack of a significant difference between moderate and high levels of flexplace.

An alternative interpretation of the lack of differences between high and moderate levels of flexplace is that discretion over how frequently one can work away from the main worksite may have a curvilinear relationship with recruitment outcomes, such that being able to work in an alternative location as frequently as desired does not result in appreciable gains over having the opportunity to do so periodically. Additional research parsing out different levels of discretion over how frequently one works away from the main worksite (e.g., 3 days a week, 1 day a month) is needed to determine whether this is true or if there is a minimum amount of flexplace necessary to have an influence. Theoretically, dramatic changes in perceptions and/or behaviours in response to small changes in one's circumstances have been explained in mathematics using catastrophe theory (Zeeman, 1976). Thus, to the extent that researchers continue to find that making flexplace an option (regardless of how much discretion is extended) results in positive outcomes, catastrophe theory may help to explain this phenomenon.

A comparison of participant ratings of flextime versus flexplace revealed that respondents rated flextime slightly higher than flexplace, suggesting that applicants value discretion over temporal boundaries a little bit more than discretion over physical boundaries. Similarly, Allen *et al.*'s (2013) meta-analysis recently revealed that flextime had stronger effects on employee work interference with family than flexplace. Perhaps, participants anticipated some of the potential downsides to working away from the main office including fewer opportunities for face-to-face networking and mentoring or they worried about how a lack of physical boundaries between work and non-work can blur the boundaries between corresponding roles resulting in more work–non-work conflict (Hill, Miller, Weiner, & Colihan, 1998).

Flextime and flexplace

Because the combination of flextime and flexplace offers employees the most control over their work boundaries, and flexplace benefits can be enriched by flextime, it was predicted that the relationship between flexplace and recruitment outcomes would be enhanced by higher levels of flextime. Although the high-high combination was perceived as the most supportive and attractive as conveyed by the mean ratings for that experimental condition, the combination of the two had additive, rather than synergistic, effects on the focal recruitment outcomes. In other words, the influence of flexplace was not dependent upon flextime. Participants in this study did not consider flextime when rating the supportiveness and attractiveness of flexplace. Each FWA dimension had its own unique influence, and the addition of the other dimension did not enrich nor diminish the effect of the other. The potential synergies that occur when employees have discretion over both temporal and physical work boundaries may not be apparent to applicants and therefore not have the expected effect on recruitment outcomes. Instead, the synergies may manifest in employee outcomes like lessened work–non-work conflict and related psychological outcomes.

Moderating effects

We also tested the extent to which individuals differ significantly in their attraction to organizations offering differing levels of flextime/flexplace based on individual and demographic differences. We found that individuals with a strong preference for integrating their work and non-work roles were significantly more attracted to organizations offering flextime and flexplace than individuals with a preference for segmenting those roles. These findings suggest that individuals vary in their preferences for managing work and non-work demands, and these preferences play a role in how attractive organizations are as potential employers. This is consistent with recent research examining boundary management styles, which suggests there are multiple ways that employees can manage work and non-work roles and that employers can more creatively support employees' management of these roles through customized work arrangements (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012).

Contrary to popular press articles that tout FWAs as policies geared more for women than men (Smithson & Stokoe, 2005), both men and women found the organization offering the most discretion over time and place as the most attractive. This may reflect new generations of workers who are attempting to distribute household chores and caretaking more equitably, thus anticipating non-work demands that may interfere with work demands constrained by traditional temporal and physical boundaries.

Contrary to expectation, the relationships between FWAs and recruitment outcomes did not depend on anticipated caregiving demands. Perhaps, the respondents in this study have not thought much about childcare/eldercare responsibilities or do not fully appreciate how difficult these demands can be. Additionally, researchers may want to consider measuring additional outcome variables such as anticipated work–non-work conflict (e.g., Westring & Ryan, 2011).

Theoretical implications

Much of the research on FWAs has studied them as human resource benefits as implemented in practice, ignoring the theoretical constructs underlying these benefits which help to explain why they are desirable and advantageous. We emphasize discretion

is a continuous construct, suggesting that there is a full range from none to unlimited discretion that can be extended to employees. Theoretically, more discretion and control is better and more desirable (Karasek, 1979). Consistent with this, our data indicated that incrementally more flextime was rated as significantly more attractive. Similarly, some discretion over where work could be conducted was rated as significantly more attractive than no discretion. Future research is needed to test whether alternative increments of discretion result in similar trends. Some researchers have noted that having too much discretion can be paralyzing, a phenomenon called the paradox of choice (Schwartz, 2004).

We proposed that applicants perceive FWAs as anticipated resources when evaluating the attractiveness of a given organization. Consistent with Conservation of Resources Theory (Hobfoll, 1989, 2001), applicants were attracted to organizations that offered more rather than less resources. Consistent with Spence's (1973) signalling theory, participants perceived organizations that offered FWAs as more supportive, and these ratings help to explain why the organizations were rated as attractive.

Researchers examining the effects of FWAs on employees have argued for the distinction between *availability* and *use* of FWAs (Butts et al., 2013; Kelly & Moen, 2007; Kossek, 2005; Kossek et al., 2006). We propose that when studying applicants, it is important to gather information on how the FWA is communicated, and the extent to which applicants perceive the arrangement is flexible. Applicants' ratings of perceived discretion over work time and place⁴ were positively related to the experimentally manipulated dimensions in a theoretically consistent manner (.46 for flextime and .63 for flexplace). These ratings of perceived discretion showed the same pattern of relationships with the outcome variables as the experimental variables, suggesting that to the extent that policy and perceptions are aligned, positive outcomes will result. Alignment of policies and perceptions sometimes break down when organizations communicate mixed or inconsistent messages to prospective employees.

Applied implications

Whereas the overall percentage of companies that offer FWAs continues to rise, many organizations have cut back on other forms of workplace flexibility (e.g., reduced hours, career flexibility; Matos & Galinsky, 2014). These trends suggest that organizations are interested in offering policies with maximum effectiveness for employees and employers (Kossek et al., 2014). The current study begins to assess the value of including information about specific FWAs in recruitment materials, which is a very common practice for attracting new talent (World at Work, 2011). By understanding the relative attractiveness of each dimension of FWAs, organizations can determine which policies will have the biggest impact.

The actual level of discretion extended to employees through various FWAs is not uniform across all organizations. For example, some organizations adhere to the prototypical flextime schedule which includes core hours, whereas other organizations do not have core hours. Additionally, the number of core hours varies across organizations (Baltes et al., 1999). Some organizations permit telework only on an *ad hoc* (as needed)

⁴ Perceived discretion over where and when one would be able to work was measured with one item each (Kossek et al., 2006, adapted for applicants) on a 5-point scale (1 = not at all, 5 = extremely). The items read, 'To what extent do you think this job would permit you to decide WHEN the work is done?' and 'To what extent do you think this job would permit you to decide WHERE the work is done?'.

basis (World at Work, 2011). The implementation of FWAs can also vary within an organization, such that only certain employees are given the option to take advantage of such benefits, based on the nature of their work, personal need, or supervisor approval (SHRM, 2013). The results from the current study provide initial individual ratings of various levels of specific FWA dimensions that correspond to existing organizational policies.

In the future, organizations offering these types of benefits should periodically assess whether potential applicants continue to perceive FWAs as attractive and facilitating corresponding states of flexibility. It would also be interesting to determine to what extent the applicants most attracted to these policies end up using them as employees and, if they do not, why not and are there any ramifications, particularly if they do not feel they can use them. Research has shown that despite having policies in place, employees do not always know about the policies or feel at liberty to take advantage of them which basically nullifies their intended purpose (Allen, 2001; Thompson, Beauvais, & Lyness, 1999). Over time, attractiveness of FWAs can change because of the prevalence with which they are offered across organizations and thus are no longer unique or rare (Barney, 1991) or because unintended consequences such as work–non-work conflict emerge due to the blurring of work and non-work boundaries.

The relatively strong effects of flextime and flexplace on the two recruitment outcomes in this study suggest that it is beneficial for organizations to offer these policies as well as to market them when recruiting new employees. The consistency in the pattern of relationships for both dimensions across two recruitment outcomes is quite compelling. Organizations that offer FWAs in addition to the other benefits are likely to have a competitive edge in recruiting new employees.

Some jobs simply cannot be conducted at alternative times or places (e.g., bus driver). Organizations that are only able to alter one dimension of FWAs (discretion over time or place) are still likely to have an advantage in recruitment over organizations that do not offer discretion over either. Alternatively, if organizations can only implement one FWA due to limited resources, then based on the results obtained here, they may want to offer flextime as it had slightly stronger effects than flexplace.

Limitations and directions for future research

To isolate the influence of flextime from flexplace, we chose to conduct a true experiment, manipulating levels of each FWA dimension independently. This calculated decision was made in an effort to maximize internal validity recognizing a trade-off in external validity. Consistent with other recruitment studies, we asked participants to rate descriptions of hypothetical organizations. This level of a control provided a low-cost approach enabling us to demonstrate preliminary evidence of the unique and possible joint effects associated with perceptions of flextime and flexplace on job seeker assessments. The effects we revealed are likely an underestimate of real-world effects given our experimental paradigm. Future research in this area should seek to replicate these findings in naturally occurring recruitment contexts and extend our research to non-recruitment-related outcomes.

Second, the participants in this study were undergraduate students who will eventually be going on the job market. College students are frequently the target of recruitment efforts by organizations. Additionally, this age group is most likely to search job vacancies on Web-based platforms (e.g., Monster.com; Dineen & Noe, 2009). Thus, these participants are likely to evaluate organizations based on vacancy characteristics such as FWAs. Using a sample of individuals seeking employment maximizes task salience (cf. Graham & Cable,

2001); thus, the participants were likely to be primed to notice and interpret differences in the organizational descriptions (Casper & Buffardi, 2004). Correspondingly, we expect our results to generalize to similar samples of potential job applicants.

Organizations that offered a high level of both flextime and flexplace were rated as the most attractive and supportive, yet the combination of the two did not yield supplementary higher ratings of support or attractiveness. There may be a threshold beyond which additional discretion does not lead to better outcomes. Alternatively, the participants in this sample may not have been able to fully anticipate the synergy that may occur when these two benefits are combined as they may not have had the opportunity to actually experience both flextime and flexplace together. Correspondingly, applicants with more job experience may be able to more critically evaluate the pros and cons of FWAs. Additional research is warranted with a sample that has actually used FWAs.

There may also be generational differences in preferences for FWAs, with younger generations preferring more discretion over temporal and physical boundaries between work and non-work (Twenge & Campbell, 2008), while older generations may be less accustomed to this blending. Younger generations of workers may even expect FWAs. In fact, there is anecdotal evidence to support this (Overmyer, 2011).

To keep the task manageable for study participants, respondents were only asked to rate positive organizational outcomes associated with offering FWAs. Future research should also examine positive and negative individual and organizational outcomes. Many have speculated that altering boundaries between work and non-work can lead to more work, work–non-work conflict, and burnout (Hill *et al.*, 1998). However, the extent to which applicants anticipate such possibilities is not clear and likely depends on their experience using such policies as well as family demands and resources.

The current study provides initial experimental evidence for the influence of flextime and flexplace on recruitment outcomes. Specifically, we isolated the effects of three levels of each FWA dimension, revealing their independent influence on AOS and organization attraction. It was also determined that these relationships were stronger for individuals who prefer to integrate rather than segment their work and non-work roles. It is hoped that the findings obtained here serve as the impetus for future research to avoid confounding flextime and flexplace so that science can better inform practice.

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Received 25 July 2013; revised version received 22 October 2014

Appendix: Example organization descriptions

After college, you will be graduating and seeking employment. Throughout your job search, you will learn about various organizations and their benefit packages and decide whether or not to pursue employment with each organization. On the first page of this survey, we ask you to read the descriptions of nine organizations and answer the questions that follow each description.

High flextime, high flexplace

Organization BCA offers the following benefits package:

- A competitive salary, with opportunities for promotion and bonuses based on performance.
- Flextime – Employees are free to work at any time they want as long as they get their work done.
- Generous benefits package including a choice of medical programs, company-matched 401(k), stock options, and maternity and paternity leave.
- Telework/telecommute – Employees may work from home via technology such as a computer.

Moderate flextime, moderate flexplace

Organization GHI offers the following recruitment package:

- A competitive salary, with opportunities for promotion and bonuses based on performance.
- Flextime with Core Hours – Employees may work any preferred 8-hr shift but must be present for core work hours of 10 am–3 pm.
- Generous benefits package including a choice of medical programs, company-matched 401(k), stock options, and maternity and paternity leave.
- Partial telework/telecommute – Employees may work from home via technology such as a computer up to 2 days a week.

Low flextime, low flexplace

Organization KMN offers the following benefits package:

- A competitive salary, with opportunities for promotion and bonuses based on performance.
- Traditional Work Schedule – 8 am–5 pm work schedule.
- Generous benefits package including a choice of medical programs, company-matched 401(k), stock options, and maternity and paternity leave.
- Traditional Work Environment – Employees must work at the main work site and are not permitted to work at home.